

polish works like slipcovers on a sofa. It's all about preservation. Therefore, beginning 24 hours after a salon visit, I religiously apply clear polish every day. It's my buffer between the harsh world and my soft hands.

3. Clean with gloves

On the highway of life, our hands pay daily tolls. Washing dishes, gardening, and other daily activities can crack, scratch, and chip our hands. For protection, wear appropriate gloves—rubber, canvas, or cotton—while completing household chores.

DIY MANICURE

The second technique—a DIY manicure—is also a money saver. You can groom and polish your own hands for less than 50 cents a session, compared to salon visits that typically cost between \$20 to \$50 per visit, plus tax and tip. Here's how I give myself a manicure, including the trendy French manicure.

4. Pay attention

A careful study of salon operators will yield valuable insights. Professional manicurists have a variety of tricks for softening, filing, and painting nails. Watch and learn.

5. Buy the right tools

Invest in sturdy but easy-to-use manicure/pedicure tools. There are also great painting kits that make it easy to apply the two-color (nude base and white tip) French manicure. It's easier to create a salon finish if you have the right tools, including a nail clipper, a pumice stone, files, and enamel. Don't forget the cotton swabs and nail polish remover. Those tools make it easier to tidy up whenever you have painted outside the lines. That's what the pros do.

6. Be patient

Painting nails is like meditating. Focus, breathe, and concentrate on a small canvas of life. Don't be afraid of making mistakes; goofs can be removed or painted over. And finally, don't rush the process. Let the paint dry or else you'll ruin a perfect 10-finger discount. If you liked these handy tips, you can find more frugal beauty secrets in my book, *The Frugal Duchess: How to Live Well and Save Money*.

—Sharon Harvey Rosenberg (*The Frugal Duchess*)